redoubtable left-wing British lawyer, D.N. Pritt, on 11 February 1931, on an application for ‘permission to appeal’ before five judges, who gave him short shrift and did not even accede to allowing the matter to go for a full hearing before it. This meant that the government lawyer on the day, A.M. Dunne, was not even called upon to put forward the government’s case. At the end of it, only one judge, Lord Dunedin, gave one short one-and-half page judgment on 27 February 1931, in the case of *Bhagat Singh v. The King Emperor*. He dismissed the appeal with the legally wrong statement that ‘although the Governor-General thought it fit to expound the reasons which induced him to promulgate this Ordinance, this was not in their Lordships’ opinion in any way incumbent on him as a matter of law,’[5] when clearly reasons had to be given to show why a state of emergency existed justifying the passing of an ordinance to try the Lahore Conspiracy accused. Almost exactly a month later, on 23 March 1931, Bhagat Singh and his two accomplices were hanged to death in Lahore Central Jail. The jail and the gallows remained intact until they were finally dismantled in the 1960s to build a residential colony. With its dismantling, the details of Bhagat Singh’s life also vanished like ether into thin air with the passage of time.

The first case, Delhi Assembly Bomb Case, arose soon after the arrest of Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt, when they were accused of throwing bombs ‘to kill or cause injuries to the King Majesty’s subjects’.[6] And they decided that they wished to be treated as ‘political prisoners’ and not as common criminals. This was important to them because their action had been castigated as an ‘outrage’ and the pair described as ‘lunatics’. Soon afterwards, the two prisoners found themselves in the sessions court before the magistrate, F.B. Pool, on 7 May 1929. A sessions court is a court of law which exists in a number of Commonwealth countries. It is the highest criminal court in a district and it is the court of first instance for trying serious offences, that is to say, those which carry a punishment of imprisonment of seven years or more, life imprisonment or death. It is called a sessions court because it was designed to sit in consecutive sessions, hearing one case after another and giving instantaneous rulings and thus disposing of cases quickly. Ironically, the practice of this